

"The Devil has
my consent,
**and goes and
hurts them."**

ABIGAIL HOBBS IN HER TESTIMONY, SEPTEMBER 1692

CONFESSING TO WITCHCRAFT

The Salem witch trials, a series of hearings for people accused of witchcraft (see pp. 122–123), took place in colonial Massachusetts between February 1692 and May 1693. While many of the women accused were innocent of any wrongdoing, prosecutors tortured or coerced them into confessing to practicing magic. Confession was one way in which accused women could delay their execution, as it led to them being questioned and asked to give up their companions. This was the case for teenager Abigail Hobbs, who admitted to giving her soul to the devil, taking part in the witches' sabbath, and killing her neighbors, but she also accused many others, including Salem's former minister George Burroughs. Her accusations led to a spate of trials, but Hobbs herself was granted a reprieve from execution in 1693 when the trials collapsed. Many depictions of the trials romanticized women who confessed—as in this example from 1892, showing a witch summoning powers to incapacitate her prosecutor.

